

FOURFOLD DESCRIPTION OF SOUND: A VEDIC VIEW

AUTHOR: M.G. PRASAD

EDITORS: BAL RAM SINGH, GIRISH NATH JHA, UMESH KUMAR SINGH, DIWAKAR MISHRA

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ABSTRACT

- Acoustics deals with generation, transmission, and reception of sound, holding high importance in vedas and vedic literature.
- Classical hindu literature (sanatana dharma) is rooted in vedas.
- Modern sound: pressure waves in audible range (20-20,000 hz); infra- and ultra-sound beyond this range.
- Vedic terms nada and sabda refer to vibrations encompassing physical and spiritual aspects, including audible sound.
- Human speech, vocal, and instrumental music within audio range discussed extensively in vedas.
- Paper presents vedic fourfold description of sound in human speech and relates it to modern acoustics.

INTRODUCTION

- Veda: body of knowledge covering physical, psychological, and spiritual aspects of life and cosmos; etymologically from "vid" meaning "to know."
- Vedas include mantras as "chants that convey knowledge" with acoustical features like phonetics, tonal quality, length measure, effort.
- Vedic chants orally transmitted precisely from master to disciple over thousands of years; oral precision surpasses writing.
- Speech faculty revered as vagdevi (goddess of speech).
- Yajurveda mantra: creator brahma and devata manifested vagdevi for communication; all beings communicate through her; may she bless with food, strength, and speech.
- Origin of language and speech difficult to define precisely.
- Vedic chants and music in india ancient; c.V. Raman quote on tracing musical development from rgveda to present indian music.

SPEECH PRODUCTION: A MODERN VIEW

- Scientific question on sound origin addressed via human speech; extensive literature on speech and music.
- Honda's four processes: (a) language processing (content to phonemic symbols in brain's language center); (b) motor commands to vocal organs in brain's motor center; (c) articulatory movement by vocal organs; (d) emission of air from lungs as speech.
- Emphasis on neurological and physiological basis.
- Paper intends to explore speech sounds and production from vedic view.

IMPORTANCE OF SOUND FIELD: VEDIC VIEW

- Vedas and literature as source for sanatana dharma, including sciences and arts.
- Vedas: collections of orally transmitted mantras.
- UNESCO recognition: vedic language from classical sanskrit; chanted in rituals, recited daily; value in content and preservation techniques using tonal accents, pronunciation, speech combinations (intangible cultural heritage 2003).
- Precision in oral transmission tied to acoustics; taittiriya upanisad's six factors: varsah (pronunciation), svarah (pitch), matra (duration), balam (force), sama (melodious articulation), santanu? (Combined effects).
- Sound from humans (speech, music) part of nada and sabda as "sound field"; manifestations generated from it.

IMPORTANCE OF SOUND FIELD: VEDIC VIEW

- Sara?Gadeva quote: alphabets from nada, words from alphabets, speech from words; world dependent on nada.
- Sri ranga sadguru analogy: from spiritual light (seed) develop nada, svara, ak?Aras into knowledge aspects.
- Sound field links to universe origins; am?Ta bindu upani?Ad: realize sabda brahman and param brahman; mastery of sabda leads to param.
- Knowledge of sabda/nada prerequisite for spiritual fulfillment.
- Nada brahman: blissful, in all beings as consciousness manifesting universe (sara?Gadeva).
- Two types: anahata (unproduced, experienced in deep yoga); ahata (produced by vibration); paper focuses on ahata.

FOUR STAGES OF SPEECH SOUNDS: VEDIC VIEW

- Taittiriya brahmaṣa hymn: speech has four stages known by brahmaṣa with mind control; three concealed in cave, fourth as human utterances.
- Philosophers of grammar: (a) para, (b) pasyanti, (c) madhyama, (d) vaikhari.
- Scriptures refer to dhvani as voice related to speech sounds.
- Saraṣadeva: human impels mind, mind activates body power source stimulating vital force; vital force from navel rises through heart, cerebrum, mouth to manifest dhvani.
- Four stages in process: (a) impelling mind; (b) mind activating vital force; (c) vital force rising through navel, heart, throat, cerebrum, mouth; (d) dhvani produced to receiver.

PARA, PASYANTI, MADHYAMA AND VAIKHARI

- Vedic view: verbal speech origin at muladhara cakra (coccygeal triangle, spinal cord end); primary energy center supporting body.
- Prapañcasara tantra verse: para unmanifest, becomes pasyanti at navel (knowledge to speech); rises to madhyama at heart (intellect integration); to vaikhari at throat/mouth (heard speech); via vital force through suśūmna channel.
- Classical verse: para at muladhara cakra, pasyanti at nabhi (navel), madhyama at hṛd (heart), vaikhari at kaśha (throat).
- Similar in bhagavata puraṇa 11.12.17.

FOUR STAGES OF SPEECH SOUNDS: VEDIC VIEW

- Psychological verse: vaikhari gross words; madhyama memory level; pasyanti motive seen; para subtle unmanifest brahman.
- Integrates physiological/psychological: vaikhari (words/sentences, vital force at throat/mouth); madhyama (memory/vocabulary, at heart); pasyanti (purpose seen, at navel); para (potential energy, base of spine).
- Whole body involved in speech/music production.

RELEVANCE OF THE VEDIC FOURFOLD MODEL OF SPEECH

- Modern view: role of brain, lungs, vocal organs (throat, mouth).
- Vedic view: integrates four levels physiologically (base of spinal cord as energy source driving vital force to lungs, heart, throat, mouth) and psychologically (memory, motive via brain).
- Vedic more comprehensive; views speech as divine energy for spiritual development.

CONCLUDING REMARKS

- Vedic fourfold approach provides deep insight; ongoing efforts to analogize universe creation as para, pasyanti, madhyama, vaikhari.
- Observation from manifest (vaikhari) to unmanifest (para); vmpp model for understanding life/nature from sound to silence.
- Continuous vital force link from para to vaikhari; reverse path possible spiritually.
- Vaikhari last quarter but fully manifest, encompassing life expressions: speech (transactions), music (artistic), literature (poetry/plays), spirituality (rituals/meditation with mantras).
- Yoga types based on sound: mantra-yoga, nada-yoga, japa-yoga, svara-yoga.
- Further theoretical/practical work needed; fourfold model helpful.
- Understanding sound field brings joy.